considered necessities, like cooking oil and toilet paper – to foreigners and to the few fortunate Cubans who had access to dollars (Figure 7.1). Until just over a year before, Cubans could have been arrested for possessing dollars. Was capitalism coming to Cuba in the wake of the loss of Soviet trade and aid?

Figure 7.1 A dollar store in Havana, 2008

Source: Photo by Aviva Chomsky



The dollar stores looked a little bit like supermarkets in the First World – but only a little bit. Some shelves were empty. Some shelves held long rows of a single brand of a single item. There was no competition or advertising. All of the stores were owned by the state. Large signs promoted their purpose: “Captación de divisas” – the capture or collection of [foreign] currency. The stores were part of a larger project to bring hard currency into the country, and into the socialist system.

These government-run stores symbolized the contradictions of Cuba’s tentative, partial opening to capitalism in the 1990s. The stores sold luxury items and even basics that were not available in the peso economy. The profits from the stores were to be used to fund state services for the benefit of all, but the system put the government in the paradoxical position of fostering inequality to subsidize equality.